

Prologue

At four years old, when Camila Sosa Villada was still Cristian Omar, she learned to write her full name, but she refused to pee standing up. Her father went from proud to furious and offered her at that moment an instant panorama of what would be in front of the rest of her life: shame, fear, intolerance, disdain, and incomprehension, if she did not bend to the paternal mandate, the cultural mandate. The future Camila didn't bend precisely and so began the punishments, the hours closed in a room, the extraordinary process of beginning to happen inside there. "My dad and my mom always knew what happened in that confinement: I dressed myself as a woman and wrote. This expelled them from my world and saved me from their hate: my romance with myself, my prohibited woman."

The first thing that I knew of Camila Sosa was a TEDx Talk that she gave in Cordoba, 13 extraordinary minutes that began with a brutal prognosis that her father made: "One day they are going to knock on the door to tell me that they found you dead, thrown in a ditch." This was the only destiny possible for a *varón* that dressed like a woman: prostitute himself or end up in a ditch. The rest of that talk by Camila was about *las travestis* in the legendary red zone of the Sarmiento Park, in Cordoba Capital, who she went to spy on one night, dead with fear, having recently arrived from her village to study journalism in university. Esas travestis saw how she looked so tender and vulnerable that they adopted her that very night. With them, says Camila, "I learned how much my body was worth and what price I had to put upon it. With them I learned to defend myself and to look two times at a person before judging them. I wouldn't be here today if they had not defended me from police and shitty clients. I would be in a ditch, surely."

When she arrived from her village to the capital at 18, she took courses during the day, worked during the night in Sarmiento Park, and wrote a blog named *La novia de Sandro*. She

wrote the blog by hand, on the back of her notes from class, arriving at dawn to her dormroom, and after going to the cybercafé and typing it. One day she discovered the workshops for theater that happened at the University. A little bit after she abandoned social communication and immersed herself in acting. The day that her career as an actress began she erased the blog entirely to hide that past.

Allow me to return for a moment to the times of Mina Clavero. When he was 13 years old, Cristian Omar wrote a love story about his gym professor. He wrote it in the feminine, baptizing himself Soledad, and showed it to his only confidant in the world, a classmate in his grade, who of course betrayed her and went with the papers to the school principal's office. The punishment was a month of confinement and of course the destruction of the story. For this same time, she discovered that her mother and her father wrote letters where they told things that they could never have said looking each other in the eyes. She discovered them but she could not read them: her mother burned them first.

With that blog the exact opposite happened. An anonymous fan had copied it before she erased it. And when Camila had already had her popular roles in the movie *Mía*, the miniseries *La viuda de Rafael*, and the one person show *Carnes Tolendas*, he sent it to her by mail. Camila sat down to read it and suddenly saw her past from another perspective from the other side of the telescope. "When I started to dress myself as the other gender, I was ashamed of my rough beard, my lopsided nose, my crooked teeth. I was ashamed to have to make my boobs from the corners of a mattress. I was ashamed of my lack of schooling, my lack of the world, my ineptitude in expressing myself. Even my virtues made me ashamed because those were born of my errors, of my shortcomings." Now, however, what she saw in the text of that blog was the unwavering

attitude, revolutionary, exemplary of the sister of *travesties*, looked badly upon, loved badly, treated badly, paid badly, judged badly, and spoken badly of.

This was the origin of this book, that is the alchemy that happened in those pages: the transformation of the shame, the fear, the intolerance, the contempt, the incomprehension, in high prose. Because *Las malas* is an account of childhood and the initiation rights, a fairytale and a terror, a group portrait, a political manifesto, an explosive memory, are guided visit to the imagination of its author and the distinct chronology unlike any other which comes to pollinate literature. In its DNA converge the two facets of the trans world that most repel and terrify good society: the *travesti* fury and the party of being a *travesti*. And in her literary voice coexist the three parts of Camila's Holy Trinity, the part of Marguerite Duras, the part of Wislawa Szymborska, and the part of Carson McCullers. The appropriation of Lorca and Jean Cocteau Camilla did on stage happens again in these pages with what she managed to soak up from Duras, Wislawa, and Carson, without losing in any moment the *cordobesa* tone that she has.

To put it frankly, *Las malas* is the kind of book that as soon as we finish reading it we want the entire world to read it.

"I had to invent my own roles because no one had thought of roles for *travestis* like me," said Camila once. "My first official act of *travestismo* was to write, before going to the street dressed as a woman," she said on another occasion. "I want to show the body of a *travesti* undressed, not the one seen in pornography, so that it is understood that the point of my existence is always great contradiction and convenience," I heard her say recently. But my favorite phrase of all of hers is: "Did you ever think that poetry could have such a concrete form?."

In the tremendous finale of that TEDx talk, Camila said that she had accepted giving it for only one reason: the need to ask for forgiveness from that Sisterhood of *travestis*. Because

she has never looked for them, and she has never seen them since when she left prostitution, years later, when she returned to read that blog that had been thought erased, it was too late to find them. The *travesti* life: one year of theirs is equal to seven "normal" years. In a "normal" world, in a world of shit, Camila and her sisters wouldn't have the slightest chance to meet again. But here, in *Las malas*, she achieves reuniting them all, in their most absolute splendidness and shivering nakedness, and when she has given them all hugs, she says to them: "Did you ever think that poetry could have such a concrete form?"

Juan Forn

The night is dark: it freezes over the Park. Very ancient trees that have just lost their leaves seem to beg the sky for something indecipherable, but vital for the vegetation. A group of *travestis* makes its round. They go, protected by the grove. They seem like part of the same organism, cells of the same animal. They move like that, as if they were a herd. The clients pass in their automobiles, they decrease their speed upon seeing the group and from among all the *travestis*, they choose one whom they call with a gesture. The chosen one goes to the call. Thus it is night after night.

Sarmiento Park is found in the heart of the city. A large green lung, with a zoo and an amusement park. At night, it becomes wild. The *travestis* wait under the branches or in front of the automobiles, they parade their spell through the mouth of the wolf in front of the statue of Dante, the historic statue that gives its name to that avenue. The *travestis* climb each night from that hell that no one writes about, to return spring to the world.

With this group of *travestis*, there is also a pregnant woman, the only one born a woman among all of them. The others, the *travestis*, have transformed themselves to be so. In the comarca of *travestis* of the Park, she is the different one, that pregnant woman who repeats the same joke since always: taking by surprise the crotch of the *travestis*. Right now she does it and all laugh out loud.

The cold does not stop the caravan of *travestis*. A flask of whiskey goes from hand to hand, papers of cocaine visit all the noses one by one, some huge and natural others small and operated. What nature does not give you, hell does. There, in that Park, contiguous to the center of the city, the body of the *travestis* borrows from hell the substance of its spell.

La Tía Encarna participates in the coven with a fierce enthusiasm. She is exultant after the *merca*. She knows herself eternal. She knows herself invulnerable like an ancient stone idol.

But something that comes from the night and the cold summons her attention, separates her from her friends. From the thicket, something calls her. Between the laughs and the whiskey that comes and goes from one painted mouth to another between the honking of those who pass looking for a turn of happiness with the *travestis*, La Tía Encarna distinguishes the sound of other provenance emitted by something or someone that is not like the rest of the people that we see here.

The other *travestis* follow the round without paying attention to the movements of La Tía Encarna. La Tía has become forgetful, telling the same old anecdotes over and over again. The most recent and nearer things have no place in her memory, a moment arrives in life when no memory is safe from. Since then, she writes everything down in little notebooks. She sticks notes on the refrigerator door as a way to beat the forgetfulness. Some think she is going crazy, others believe she has stopped remembering out of exhaustion. Many blows La Tía Encarna has suffered, police boots and clients have played soccer with her head and also with her kidneys. Blows to the kidneys make her urinate blood so no one gets worried when she leaves when she abandoned them when she responds to the siren of her destiny.

She walks away a bit disoriented, harassed by the acrylic shoes that at her 178 years feel like a bed of nails. She walks with difficulty through the dry earth and the wild weeds that grow untended, she crosses the Dante Avenue like a whistle toward the zone of the Park, where there are thorns and vines and a cave in which the *maricas* go to give each other kisses and comfort, and which they have nicknamed La Cueva Del Oso. A few meters away is the Hospital Rason, the hospital that takes care of the infections. Our second home.

Ditches, abysses, bushes that hurt, drunks masturbating. While La Tía Encarna loses herself among the thicket, the magic begins to happen. The *putas*, the hot couples, the fortuitous

pick ups, those who managed to find each other in this improvised forest, all give and receive pleasure inside the cars parked at random, or lying among the weeds, or standing against the trees. At that hour, the Park is like a womb of joy, a vessel of sex without shame. One cannot distinguish where the caresses or the licks come from. At that hour, in that place, the couples are fucking.

But La Tía Encarna pursues something like a sound or a perfume. It is never possible to know when one sees her go after something. Gradually, that which has summoned her is revealed. It is the cry of a baby. La Tía Encarna probes the air with her shoes in her hand, burying herself in the inclement weather of the terrain to see it with her own eyes.

Much hunger, and much thirst. That is what is felt in the clamor of the baby and it is the cause of the tribulation of La Tía Encarna, who enters the forest with desperation because she knows that in someplace there is a child who suffers, and in the Park it is winter, and the frost is so strong that it freezes the tears.

Encarna approaches the gutters where the *putas* hide when they see the lights of the police approaching and finally, she finds him. Some thorny branches cover the child. He cries with desperation, the Park seems to cry with him. La Tía Encarna gets very nervous, all the terror of the world clings to her throat at that moment.

The child is wrapped in an adult jacket and inflatable green jacket. He looks like a bald parrot. When she tries to take him out of his tomb of branches, she pricks her hands with thorns and the punctures begin to bleed, staining the sleeves of her blouse. She looks like a midwife, putting her hands inside a mare to extract the foal. She does not feel pain. She does not pay attention to the cuts that those thorns make on her. She continues, pushing branches aside and

finally rescues the child who howls in the night. He is completely shit-filled. The smell is unbearable.

Between the retching and the blood, La Tía Encarna holds him against her chest and begins to call her friends at the top of her lungs. Her screams have to travel to the other side of the avenue. It is difficult for them to hear her.

But the *travesti* bitches of the Parque Sarmiento in the city of Córdoba hear much more than any vulgar human. They hear the call of La Tía Encarna because they smelled the fear in the air and they get alert. Goosebumps hair standing on end, gills open, jaws in tension.

"*Travestis* of the Park! Come! Come, I have found something!," she shouts.

A child of about three months abandoned in the Park. Covered with branches, placed there so that death could do with him whatever it wanted. Even the dogs and the wildcats that lived there in all parts of the world, children are a banquet. The *travestis* approach with curiosity they look like an invasion of zombies, approaching hungrily to the woman with the baby in her arms one takes her hands to her mouth, hands so big they could cover the entire sun. Another exclaims that the child is precious, a jewel. Another immediately turns on her heels and says.

"I have nothing to do with this. I didn't see anything."

"That's how they are," responds another, wanting to say that's how these good *putos* are when the shoe pinches.

"We are going to have to call the police," says one.

"No!," La Tía Encarna shouts. "Not the police! You cannot take a child to the police. There's no worse punishment!"

"But we can't have him," argues a voice that appeals to reason

"The child stays with me. He goes home with us."

"But how are you going to carry him, if he is all shit filled in full of blood?"

"Inside the purse. He fits entirely."

The *travestis* walk from the Park to the terminal area with surprising speed. A caravan of cats by the circumstances, with their heads bowed very low, making them invisible. They go to La Tía Encarna's house, the most *maricon*a boarding house in the world which is taken in hidden, protected, and sheltered, so many *travestis* and moments of hopelessness. They go there because they know they couldn't be safer anywhere else. They carry the child in a purse.

One of them, the youngest, dares to say what they have all already communicated with their thoughts:

"It's too cold to sleep in the cell."

"What are you saying?" asks La Tía Encarna.

"Nothing, just that: it's too cold to sleep in the cell. And even more so for kidnapping a baby."

I am dead with fear. I walk behind them, almost running. The vision of the child has emptied me inside. It is as if suddenly I had no organs nor blood nor bones nor muscles. It is partly panic and partly determination, two matters that do not always go hand-in-hand. The girls are nervous, vapor and sighs of fear escape from their mouths.

They pray to all the Saints that the child does not wake up, that he does not cry, that he does not scream like he screamed a moment ago in the Park, like a pig in the slaughterhouse. They cross paths with cars driven by drunks who scream barbarities at them, patrol cars that slow down upon seeing them trash students to go out to buy cigarettes.

Just by bowing their heads the *travestis* achieve the gift of transparency. It has been given to them at the moment of their baptism. They go as if they were meditating and repressing the fear of being discovered because one must be a *travestis* and carry a newborn covered in blood inside a purse to know what fear is.

They arrive at La Tía Encarna's house, a two-story mansion painted pink that looks abandoned and receives them with open arms. They enter through an undecorated hallway and go directly to the patio surrounded by glass doors from which faces of *travestis* appear with immense curiosity in their eyes. From the rooms above, comes a voice in falsetto that sings a sad song that is extinguished by the commotion. One of the girls prepares the tub, another runs to the pharmacy on duty for diapers and powdered milk for newborns, another looks for clean sheets and towels, another a joint. La Tía Encarna speaks to the child in a very low voice, initiates the litany, sings to him quietly, bewitches him so he stops crying. She undresses the child, takes off her own shit covered dress too, and just like that half naked next to her friends, they bathe him on the kitchen table.

Some dare to joke, despite being with their asses puckered, as one says, because of that delirium of taking the child with them, of rescuing him, and keeping him like a pet. They begin to wonder what he will be called, where he could've come from, who could've been the bad mother who abandoned him in the Park. One dares to say that if the mother had the courage to throw him into a ditch like that, she surely would not have given him a name. Another says he has the face of being called *El Brillo de los Ojos* (The Sparkle in the Eyes). Another makes her shut up for being poetic and reminds them that there is danger.

The police are going to make their sirens roar, they are going to use their weapons against the *travestis*. The news shows are going to scream, the newsrooms are going to catch fire, society

is going to clamor always willing to lynch. Childhood and *travestis* are incompatible. The image of a *travestis* with a child in her arms is a sin for that scum. The idiots will say it is better to hide them from their children, so they do not see to what extent a human being can be a degenerate. Despite knowing all that the *travestis* are there accompanying La Tía Encarna's delirium.

What happens in that house is the complicity of orphans.

Once the child is clean and wrapped in a sheet like a cannelloni, La Tía Encarna sighs and rests in her room, decorated like a sultan's chamber. Everything there is green. Hope is in the air. In the light. That room is the place where good faith is never lost.

Little by little the house falls into silence. The *travestis* have retreated, some to sleep, others to the street again. I throw myself to sleep on a sofa in the dining room. They have given the child a bottle, as he was dying of hunger, and they have grown tired of looking at him, of trying out names, of claiming relationships. When he grew tired of crying, the child devoted himself to looking at them, with an intelligent curiosity, straight into the eyes of each one. That had made an impression on them, they had never felt looked at in that way.

The big pink house, the most *travestis* pink in the world (in every window there are plants that tangle with other plants, fertile plants that give flowers like fruit, where the bees dance) has suddenly become silent, so as not to scare the child. La Tía Encarna bares her silicone filled chest and brings the baby to it. The child sniffs the hard giant tit and latches on with tranquility. He will not be able to extract a single drop of milk from that nipple, but the *travestis* woman who carries him in her arm, pretends to breastfeed him, and sings him a lullaby. No one in this world has ever really slept if a *travestis* has not sung them a lullaby.

María, a very young and a bit frail deaf-mute passes by me like a succubus and opens Encarna's door without asking, but with great delicacy and finds that scene La Tía Encarna breast-feeding a newborn with her chest filled with airplane oil. La Tía Encarna is about ten centimeters off the ground from the peace she feels in her whole body at that moment, with that child who drains the historical pain that inhabits her. The best kept secret of wet nurses, the pleasure, and the pain of being drained by a pup. A painful injection of peace. La Tía Encarna has her eyes rolled back in absolute ecstasy. She whispers, bathed in tears that slide down her tits and fall onto the child's clothes.

With her fingers joined in a little bunch, María asked her what she was doing. Encarna answers she doesn't know what she is doing, that the child latched onto her tit and she didn't have the courage to take it out of his mouth. María, the Mute, crosses her fingers over her chest, letting her know that she cannot breastfeed, that she has no milk.

"It doesn't matter," responds La Tía Encarna. "It's just a gesture," she says.

Maria shakes her head and with delicacy closes the bedroom door. In the darkness, she hit her toes against the leg of a table and covers her mouth so she doesn't scream. Her eyes fill with tears. Upon seeing me, she points to La Tía's room, and with the same finger draws circles on her temple, to tell me that Encarna has gone crazy.

A gesture nothing more. The gesture of a female who obeys her body, and then this way the child remains united to that woman like Romulus and Remus to Luperca.

From the sofa that they granted me to sleep on tonight, I remember what was always said in my house about my birth. My mom was in labor for two days, unable to dilate and unable to endure the pain. The doctors refused to perform until my dad threatened the doctor in charge of

the matter with death. He put a gun to his temple and told him that if he didn't operate on his wife, so the child could be born, he would be dead before the night was over.

That was what they said about me afterward: I had been born under a threat. My dad would repeat that same attitude with me time and time again from then on. Everything they gave me, every desire, every love, every decision made, he would threaten with death. My mom said that since my birth she had to take Lexotanil to sleep, which must've been the reason for her indifference, for her passivity before her son's life. Everything is the opposite of what is happening now behind that door, in the room that continues with the light on. A green globe blinds with death and threatens it with life. It warns that it must retreat, forget about the child found in the Park, warn it that it no longer has jurisdiction in the house.

From my sofa, covered with the coats of the other *travestis* of the house. I fall asleep with the lullaby that Encarna intones for the child. The story I heard one thousand times of my painful birth dissolves like sugar in tea. In that *travestis* house, sweetness can still make death recoil. In that house, even death can be beautiful.

If someone wanted to make a reading of our homeland, of this homeland for which we have sworn to die in every anthem sung in the school patios, this homeland that has taken lives of young people in its wars, this homeland that has buried people in concentration camps, if someone wanted to make an exact record of that shit, then they should see the body of La Tía Encarna. That is also what we are as a country, the damage to the body of the *travestis*. The trace left on certain bodies in an unjust, random, and avoidable way, that trace of hatred.

La Tía Encarna was one hundred and seventy-eight years old. La Tía Encarna had cuts of all kinds made by her own hand in prison (because it is always better to be in the infirmary than

in the heart of the violence) and also the fruit of street fights, miserable clients, and surprise attacks. She even had a scar on her left cheek that gave her a ruinous and mysterious air. Her boobs and her hips carried eternal bruises because of the beatings received when she had been detained, even in the times of the *milicos* (she swore that during the dictatorship she had met the evil man face-to-face).

No, I take it back: those bruises were from the airplane oil with which she had molded her body, that Italian mama body that fed her, paid for the light, the gas, the water to irrigate that patio beautifully dominated by vegetation, that patio that was the continuation of the Park, just as her body was the continuation of the war.

La Tía Encarna had arrived in Córdoba very young, when you could still navigate a boat on the Suquía River without burying yourself in the garbage. She had surrounded herself with *travestis* all her life. She defended us from the police, she gave us advice when our hearts were broken, she wanted to emancipate us from the *chongo*. She wanted us to liberate ourselves. For us not to swallow the fairytale of romantic love. For us to take care of other business, we, the emancipated. From capitalism. From the family. From social security.

Her maternal instinct was theatrical, but it dominated her character as if it were authentic. She exaggerated like a mother, controlled like a mother, was cruel like a mother. She had a very low threshold for offense and became resentful easily.

In Formosa, she had hitched herself to a truck driver from Chaco with whom they had started the story well. She was young, recited poems by Gabriella Mistral from memory, and swore that her dream was to be a rural teacher, but trucks were her life. "Being a truck *puta* is another story, it's another landscape. Truckers are important guys on the road, they are serious business," she would say. Even in Córdoba, now calm, installed in the Park, voluntarily and

forever distanced from the past, she often returned to the towns on the route where the truckers made their stops.

She had injected airplane oil into her boobs, buttocks, hips, and cheekbones. She said that besides being economical, it resisted the thrust better. But the injected areas had filled with unpleasant bruises, and the liquid had shifted in every direction, leaving her full of lumps and craters like the lunar surface. Because of this she always forced herself to work with the lights very low. On her left knee, she had two ugly bullet scars which went out just as they had come in and on rainy days, it was common to see her limping to the kitchen for a glass of water to take a painkiller because the pain made her tremble.

Rainy days were a party: we didn't go out to work. Or, if we had already gone out and the downpour started, we all took a taxi together to her boarding house. On the way the taxi drivers would bust a gut laughing with us. You had to hear them laugh in that moment to realize that we were truly funny, valuable, that we did good things, too.

We played cards, watched porn movies, or some soap opera on television, advised the new girls after the baby's arrival, we also became experts on childhood, but we kept the secret. María, the deaf-mute, was in charge of taking care of him when the adoptive mother had to run an errand. No one should know there was a child in the house. Such was our degree of unconsciousness. But also a responsibility. We knew that in any other place, that child would simply not receive affection, and in La Tía Encarna's house he was loved.

Finally, we had baptized him after a democratic vote. By majority we chose to call him. El Brillo de Los Ojos, (The Sparkle of the Eyes), and it was very good to call him that because La Tía Encarna, and all of us really, recovered the sparkle in our gaze when we were with him.

So as soon as we entered that big pink house, we would ask: "Where is The Sparkle of the Eyes?" and we would go pick him up and say: "How beautiful The Sparkle of the Eyes?" Or talking among ourselves, we would say: "When The Sparkle of the Eyes grows up," and it was a language very much our own. Sometimes we simply asked where María was, and someone would answer: "There, talking to The Sparkle of the Eyes," and we would peek in and find the speed of Maria's hands astonishing as she spoke to the child who looked at her mesmerized and returned the sparkle to her gaze.

The Sparkle of the Eyes was brown-skinned, solid, with little slanted eyes like a sad Chinese man. As the days passed, he grew stronger, cried less and dared to smile at us. I helped with songs, putting him to sleep in my arms. "Go with *la tía* Camila," La Tía Encarna would say when she got tired of holding him, and she would hand him to me and I would take him for a walk around the house. Sometimes I would sit on the terrace and think: a child, a husband, a house, a patio, flowers in the pots, a library, receiving friends on the weekend, leaving prostitution, reconciling with my parents.

Rainy days were also a party in my childhood in Mina Clavero, the town that witnessed how I began to convert the body of the son of a hustler couple into a *travestis*.

When it rained in summer, I could stay home and not go to work. Having been born into poverty, I was destined to work. "He has to learn to earn a living from a young age," my dad would say, and he would hang a cooler full of ice cream over my shoulder and send me to the riverbank to sell them. The word was shame. I couldn't feel a greater shame than that: the confirmation of poverty. Begging people to buy ice cream from me, already learning back then the tricks of commerce that I would put into practice to sell my body: saying what the clients want to hear. In that damn town with that damn river.

That's why the rain will always be a blessing. Because when it rained, I didn't have to go to the riverbank to sell ice cream to the tourists, who were and are the worst thing that ever existed. Since we were poor at home, child labor was a very dignified thing, and I worked to pay for the school uniform, the supplies, while my schoolmates were on vacation. At nine years old, I endured the pity with which tourists looked at the poor faggot boy selling ice cream, the progressives who thought I was being exploited, like that big guy who one day invited me into his tent and showed me his huge, hard, perfect dick, and asked if I liked it, and I told him yes, and he invited me to caress it but carefully because it bit and I set aside the styrofoam box full of ice cream and he told me to take one out and smear it on his dick, and my mouth froze, and I got scared, and I didn't like the taste, and everything became a disaster because the ice cream had dripped onto his pubis and left it sticky, so he told me I was useless, which was something I frequently heard from my dad's mouth, and he threw me out of the tent telling me not to even think about opening my mouth. I walked away from the river, counting a few bills I had earned with the ice cream and went back home, pretending I was sick. And, sure enough, just by saying those words the fever rose and I was able to stay in bed for three days, remembering the smell of dampness inside the tent, the perfume of the *chongo*, his beautiful penis, and the horrible taste that I still can't explain why we like so much if it taste so bland.

"Dicks don't taste like anything," La Tía Encarna used to say. She would caress you and say: "Lower your head when you want to disappear, but keep your forehead high the rest of the year, girl." And she was like a mother, like an aunt, and all of us were standing there in her house, looking at the child stolen from the Park, in part because she had taught us to resist, to defend ourselves, to pretend we were loving people punished by the system, to smile in the

supermarket checkout line, to always say thank you and please, all the time. And sorry, too, a lot of sorry, which is what people like to hear from *putas* like us.

So since I met La Tía Encarna, I made it a habit to lie a lot to the common people and I say please and thank you to anyone and sorry, too, in all colors, and people feel good and stop bothering you for a moment.

Every nasty trick from people is like a headache that lasts for days. A powerful migraine that isn't lessened by anything. All day long the insults, the mockery. All the time the lack of love, the lack of respect. The local cunning of the clients, the scams, the exploitation of the *chongos*, the submission, the stupidity of believing ourselves objects of desire, the loneliness, the AIDS, the heels of shoes that break, the news of the dead ones, the murdered ones, the fights within the clan, over men, over gossip, over bickering. All that which seems to never stop. The blows, above everything else, the blows the world gives us, in the dark, at the most unexpected moment. The blows that came immediately after fucking. We had all gone through that.

La Tía Encarna used to tell us that the least important thing in the world was men's penises. That we had our own between our legs, and we could well grab onto it when we went through moments of weak flesh. That we had to work for ourselves not to pay for any little whim of the *chongo*. And that, when we slept with a freebie (that's what we called the ones we fucked for pleasure and not for money), we should make him pay in some way for our body.

She also told us that the sorrow was very deep at one hundred and seventy-eight years old. Sometimes she felt that her legs weighed like bags of cement, that her organs turned to stone inside her body and her heart was getting hard and falling into disuse. She cried over the limits to which we were confined. She also lamented the injustices like in the case of María the Mute whom she had practically resuscitated, when she found her, curled up in a trashcan,

malnourished, covered in lice, and took her to live with her. She had given her a family, the oldest *travestis* were the godmothers, the baptism was like a new realist movie.

At thirteen, after a week in that big pink house, María had been baptized as a *travesti*. The ceremony was on the patio. While they ate nougat and drank cider, the flower of one of the cactuses had burst open suddenly, right there, in front of everyone's eyes, and began to give off a smell of rotting meat that left them bewildered. One of them asked in a high voice how it could be that the flower smelled like that, and another who was a know-it-all answered that some flowers are pollinated by flies and that's why they have to smell like rotting meat to attract them. But that doesn't stop them from being beautiful and magnetic, capable of leaving a group of *travestis* speechless as they carry out their intimate ritual of baptism and loyalties.

That was the era of flowers in our clan, despite the death sentence of which we were victims. It was the era of smelling each other like bitches and pollinating each other. The arrival of The Sparkle of the Eyes had turned our resentment into a yearning to improve. La Tucu went to enroll in a high school for adults because she didn't want to die without bringing her mother, the diploma and telling her: "Look, here you go, see that I could do something for myself?" But they had treated her so badly at the school where she registered that after her first day of class, she had appeared crying through the Park and had started screaming that tonight she was going to fuck without a condom until she was sick of it, since nothing mattered at all anyway. La Tía Encarna had rubbed her face with slaps that night and sent her to the boarding house to rest.

The cure for all our ills was rest. For any illness of the body or the soul, La Tía Encarna prescribed rest. It was the greatest gift anyone had ever given us in life: letting us rest and having her take care of the watch.

We orbited around her. In her house, there was always something to eat, and since we often went back hungry, she welcomed us with arms open and bread on the table. By day I lived the life of a mediocre student, and the poverty was a lot. Now I can say the hunger was a lot. The fact that eating only bread deforms the body, makes it sad. The absence of color in food is sad and demoralizing, but in La Tía Encarna 's house the cupboards were always full. If you lacked something she gave it to you: flour, sugar, oil, yerba, what couldn't be missing in any house and she told all of us that an image of the Virgin of the Valley couldn't be missing in our room either, who was dark skinned and rebellious, and so powerful that she twisted destinies.

We had known La Tía Encarna to have only one love: a quiet and lasting romance with a headless man. In those years, a number of refugees from wars fought in Africa had appeared in the city. They arrived in our country with the desert sand still stuck to their shoes and it was said they had lost their heads in combat. Women went crazy for them because their tenderness, their sensuality, and their willingness to play were legendary. They had suffered many hardships in the war, almost the same as the *travestis* on the street, and then I turned them into objects of desire and war heroes at the same time. The Headless Men took accelerated Spanish courses to be able to speak our language and that was how we learned that they had lost their heads and now thought with their whole bodies and only remembered the things they had felt with their skin.

The Headless Men arrived with their novel sweetness and tenderly disappointed the women who waited for them with open legs and sex in bloom because they preferred the *travestis* of the region. We didn't know why they had chosen us, but there were many who married and grew old alongside their beloved decapitated men. They made it clear that they fell in love with us because by our side, it was easier to share the trauma, let it climb the walls or lock it away when necessary. But the women took that snub as an offense and spread sly and

malicious comments about our guests, who, after all, were like that for having fought for a better world. They said that making love with one of them was like going to the beach, you couldn't get the sand out of your ass for days and days. But we didn't care what they said.

La Tía Encarna had met him in Hangar 18, the most sinful gay club that existed in our city, the most sacreligious and Dionysian dive where the witches, faggots, and lesbians of the time used to meet. The relationship between Encarna and her Headless Man had started as a highly prosperous commercial arrangement because when they met, La Tia was at the productive peak of her body. Clients meant not the slightest wear and tear for her, so she could easily sleep with ten men a night, something that happened very often, and wake up the next day fresh and energetic like a summer wind, hugging her Headless Man, who lived comfortably in his own apartment thanks to a war veteran pension. The Headless Men came from regions, incomprehensible to our limited culture. We couldn't understand why those bloody conflicts had occurred that expelled them into our city, but they were everything that every travestis hoped for from luck. Although, of course, they were scarce, as many ended up in asylums or decided to emigrate to towns by the sea. The few who stayed in Córdoba settled down quickly, and that vanishing point closed forever.